

Revision & Polishing

ECON 692 – Applied Economics Seminar

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Before We Start: Course Feedback

Please take a few minutes **now** to fill out these two surveys.

It's anonymous, and the responses actually shape how I teach this course next year — what to cut, what to expand, what landed, what didn't.

Please fill out **both** — the official USF survey and my own.



Official USF Survey



My Personal Survey

Today's Agenda

Time	Duration	Activity
4:35	10 min	Check-in + feedback surveys
4:45	20 min	Triaging reviewer comments
5:05	60 min	Revision sprint 1: the biggest issue
6:05	10 min	Break
6:15	20 min	Polishing pass: what to look for
6:35	50 min	Revision sprint 2: polish + presentation prep
7:25	30 min	Presentation dry runs (pairs)
7:55	15 min	Wrap-up + final presentation logistics

Check-in

Final presentations start next week.

Quick show of hands:

- Who submitted a full draft last Friday?
- Who got reviewer comments back and has read them?
- Who's presenting May 7 vs. May 14?

Today's goal: leave with the biggest weakness in your draft fixed, and a presentation you've said out loud at least once.

Triaging Reviewer Comments

Not All Comments Deserve Equal Weight

You have limited time. Reviewers will flag more things than you can fix.

Triage before you revise.

Sort every comment into one of three buckets:

1. **Substantive.** The comment identifies a real flaw a reader will notice — unclear argument, missing control, weak identification story, confusing figure.
2. **Cosmetic.** Typos, wording, formatting. Easy to fix. Batch these.
3. **Ignore (with reason).** Reviewer misunderstood, out of scope, or you disagree on substance. Write down *why* you're ignoring it.

You don't have to accept every suggestion. But you do have to engage with each one.

When Reviewers Disagree

It will happen. Two reviewers contradict each other, or one says “cut this section” and the other says “expand it.”

- Both being confused about the same thing — even in different ways — usually means **the writing is the problem**, not their reading.
- If only one reviewer raised a concern, weight it by how central the issue is.
- When in doubt, go with what makes the argument clearer, not what makes the paper longer.

Heuristic

If you can't decide whether to make a change, make it. Revision is cheap; a confused reader at the final submission is not.

Pick Your One Biggest Issue

Before the sprint starts, write down the **single biggest weakness** in your draft. Not a list. One thing.

Candidates:

- The introduction doesn't make the research question clear
- The identification story has a hole
- The main figure doesn't show what I claim it shows
- The results section reports numbers without interpretation
- The conclusion restates the intro and adds nothing

Sprint 1 (60 min) is for fixing *that* thing. Everything else waits.

Revision Sprint 1

Sprint 1: Fix the Biggest Thing (60 min)

Heads down. No Slack, no email, no “just one small thing.”

Before you start:

- Write the one thing you're fixing at the top of a note
- Close everything else

I'll be circulating. If you get stuck, flag me down — don't spend 30 minutes on a sentence.

Checkpoint at 6:05

Be ready to say: “The biggest issue was X. I fixed it by doing Y.” If you can't say that, we'll talk through it.

Polishing Pass

What a Polishing Pass Actually Is

Polishing $\neq$ proofreading. Proofreading catches typos; polishing catches **places where the reader has to work too hard.**

Read your paper out loud. When you stumble, the sentence is broken.
Common stumbles:

- Long sentences with multiple clauses
- Pronouns with unclear referents (“this” — this what?)
- Acronyms introduced too late, or never
- Passive voice hiding who did what
- Paragraphs where the first sentence doesn't tell you what it's about

The Introduction Is the Only Section That Matters

That's an overstatement, but not by much. Most readers read the intro and skim the rest.

Your intro should answer, in this order:

1. What's the question?
2. Why is it hard or unresolved?
3. What do you do differently?
4. What do you find?
5. Why should the reader care?

If any of these is missing or buried past paragraph 3, fix it. The intro is where revision effort pays off most.

Tables and Figures: One Last Pass

Before submission, every table and figure needs:

- A title that states the **takeaway**, not the contents
- A caption you could read standalone and understand
- Units on every axis and every coefficient
- A note explaining the sample, standard errors, and any filters
- No raw variable names (“log_earn_2020” → “Log earnings, 2020\$”)

Rule of thumb: if a reader flipping through only to the figures could reconstruct your main result, your figures are doing their job.

Revision Sprint 2

Sprint 2: Polish + Presentation Prep (50 min)

Pick a track based on where you have the most leverage:

Paper Track

1. Rewrite your intro's first paragraph
2. Fix one table + one figure's labels/captions
3. Read one section out loud; fix stumbles

Slides Track

1. Draft your title slide + research question slide
2. Build the 1–2 result slides that carry the talk
3. Cut any slide you can't justify in a sentence

Most of you should do slides track — the paper gets one more week, but the talk needs a dry run today.

Presentation Dry Runs

Dry Run Pairs (30 min)

Pair up. Each person gets **10 minutes to talk**, then 5 minutes of feedback.

Ground rules:

- Stand up. Talk to your partner, not the screen.
- Partner times you. If you hit 10 min, they stop you.
- Even if your slides aren't done, talk through the structure.

Feedback focus (for the listener):

- Could you state the research question after hearing the talk?
- What was the clearest moment? The most confusing?
- Was there a slide you'd cut?

Presentation Logistics (May 7 & May 14)

- **10 minutes of talk + 5 minutes Q&A.** Hard cap on the 10.
- Slides due uploaded to Canvas **the night before** your presentation.
- Bring your laptop as a backup, but we'll run off the room machine.
- First presenters go 4:40; last presenter ends by 8:00.

What a good 10-minute talk looks like:

- 1 min: question + why it matters
- 2 min: data + empirical strategy
- 5 min: main results (with figures)
- 1 min: robustness / caveats
- 1 min: takeaway

Wrap-up

Next Week & Deadlines

This week:

- Weekly progress report due **Wednesday**
- Keep revising based on what you learned today

Presentations begin next week:

- **May 7:** first group of presenters
- **May 14:** remaining presenters
- **May 15:** Final paper + reproducibility package due

Before You Leave

Email me if you're presenting May 7 and want a 15-minute office-hours slot this week to run through your talk.